



Cover story | CHALLENGES OF CHANGE

CAN ART OVERCOME HATE?

“Don’t use His name as an excuse to kill each other”

SHAH RUKH KHAN ACTOR, PRODUCER AND TELEVISION ANCHOR

We are living in an uncertain world. There is uncertainty whether we sleep in Mumbai or in Delhi, in Jerusalem, Tehran or Kabul, where most of our brothers and sisters hardly get any sleep at all. This evening as we think of art, religion, peace and hatred, let us keep these sleep-deprived friends in our hearts and in our minds because honestly, we all are in the same boat. I was unwell on November 26 when Mumbai was attacked and I had a video conference with my Kolkata Knight Riders' coach in Australia. I cancelled it. A lot of my friends did, as did the parents of my children's friends. Some were fortunate, some were not. And quickly after the incident, we made our walls higher, had more security at the gate, kept more dogs but one thing that became very evident is this. There's no hiding place for any of us. We are all entirely vulnerable.

This is a new situation. It makes us appreciate in a fresh way how art can make a difference in our lives. I believe a little pessimistically; that it won't go away very soon. First, what is it about art that grabs us and focuses our attention? Art attracts us because of the riveting new patterns, textures, colours, notes, rhythms or the shades of light and dark. The moveable shapes of Gopi Kishan or Astad Deboo, the sound of the great A.R. Rahman, the art of M.F. Husain, the performances of the great Dilip Kumar and Amitabh Bachchan. It also grabs us because of the feelings deep inside us that come surging forth when we are exposed to the art form of our choice. And the third way it grabs us is the most subtle and subjective but perhaps the most important—beauty. Beauty is ineffable. It cannot be pinned down but like love, beauty totally dominates our faculties and won't let go. So, like love, I don't know where beauty comes from but I do know when I see it. Beauty mesmerises me. Beauty can be present in a man-made work of

